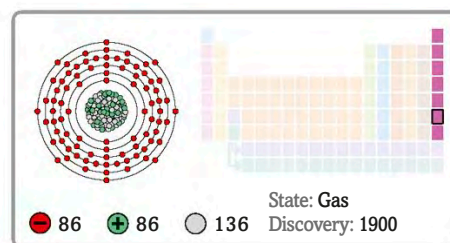


86
Rn

Radon



This uranium mineral releases radon gas, as radioactive metals in it break apart.

These yellow crystals belong to another uranium mineral called uranophane.

Uraninite



Radon is the only natural radioactive noble gas. This element is produced by the breakdown of uranium and other radioactive metals. Being a gas, radon escapes from minerals, such as **uraninite**, into the air. Radon is very radioactive and breathing it in can cause illness, such as lung cancer. In most places, the amount of radon in the air is incredibly tiny. However, its levels are high around **volcanic springs** and mud, where it bubbles out with other hot gases. Radon is also present in the water at **geothermal power plants**, which use heat energy from deep, volcanic rocks to make electricity. Radon is also more common in areas rich in granite rock. In these places, people use **test kits** to monitor their homes' radon levels.

It takes only
3.8 days for
half of radon's atoms
to split into atoms of
other elements.

Glass sphere containing radon and air

As it decays, a compound called thorium dioxide emits radon.

